

A JPP RESOURCE COLLECTION GUIDE

Our Stories *Matter*

A Family Storytelling & Legacy Guide



Listen · Remember · Preserve · Pass It Forward



For families, classrooms, libraries, congregations & communities

Why Stories Matter

A note from Jackrabbit Punkin Publishing

Every family carries stories that have never been written down. The smell of a kitchen on a Sunday afternoon. The long road someone walked to school. The reason a certain hymn or song still brings a room to its feet, or to tears. These stories live in people, and when nobody thinks to ask about them, they quietly slip away.

Our Stories Matter was made to help keep that from happening. The goal isn't to produce a perfect biography, get every date right, or finish a family tree. The goal is simpler and more important: to make space, for an afternoon, on a porch, at a kitchen table, where one person listens and another is truly heard.

When we ask someone about their life, we tell them it was worth remembering. And when we listen, we often find out that their story is part of ours.

A Guide for Every Generation

Anyone can be the listener. Anyone can be the storyteller. This guide works just as well for:

- ◆ a 58-year-old sitting down with her 85-year-old aunt
- ◆ a teenager interviewing his father
- ◆ a veteran recording another veteran's memories
- ◆ two siblings comparing what they remember of the house they grew up in
- ◆ a grandchild and a grandparent on a rainy afternoon
- ◆ a church or faith community gathering the stories of its elders
- ◆ a family reunion turning one afternoon into an archive
- ◆ a classroom, library, or community group preserving local history

How to Use This Guide

PREPARE

Read *The Art of Listening* (page 3) before you begin. It matters more than any question.

CONVERSE

Pages 4–8 hold five themes of questions. Choose a few that feel right; you don't need to ask them all.

PRESERVE

Afterward, the listener completes pages 9–10. Page 11 offers ideas for keeping the story going.

The Art of Listening

The questions open the door. Listening is what invites someone to walk through it.

1 Choose someone you'd like to know better.

A parent, an aunt, a neighbor, a longtime church member, a sibling. Curiosity is the only qualification.

2 Find a comfortable place.

Somewhere quiet and familiar: a favorite chair, a kitchen table, a porch. Turn off the television and silence phones.

3 Ask permission before recording.

Explain why you'd like to record and who might hear it. Take notes instead if they'd rather you didn't.

4 Don't rush.

Silence is often a memory arriving. Wait a moment before your next question. One good story is enough for a day.

5 Let stories wander.

If a question about school leads to a tale about a mule named Pete, follow the mule. The detours are often the treasures.

6 Don't correct their memory.

If a date or detail sounds different from what you know, let it be. This is their story, told their way. Compare notes later, if ever.

7 Every question is optional.

The storyteller can decline any question, for any reason, without explanation. Say this out loud at the start. It makes people feel safe enough to share more, not less.

What to Bring

- ◆ This guide and a pen
- ◆ A phone or recorder, charged and tested
- ◆ A photo, recipe, or object to spark memories
- ◆ Something to drink, and plenty of time

Gentle Ways to Say "Tell Me More"

"What was that like?"

"What happened next?"

"Who else was there?"

"What did it sound like? Smell like?"

AN EASY WAY TO BEGIN

"What's the earliest thing you can remember?"

Start with a question that has no wrong answer. Save the deeper questions for once you've both settled in.

Where It All Began

Childhood, home, and the everyday life that shaped who you became.

HOME & HOMETOWN

- 1 Where were you born, and where did you grow up?
- 2 Describe the house or place you lived as a child. Which room do you remember most?
- 3 What was your neighborhood or community like? Who lived nearby?

FAMILY & HOUSEHOLD

- 4 Who lived in your home when you were growing up?
- 5 What were your parents or caregivers like? What work did they do?
- 6 Which brothers, sisters, or cousins were you closest to? Why?

SCHOOL & GROWING UP

- 7 What was school like? How did you get there each day?
- 8 Is there a teacher you still remember? What made them stand out?
- 9 What did you do for fun? What did you get in trouble for?

FOOD, CELEBRATIONS & TRADITIONS

- 10 What foods remind you of home? Who made them?
- 11 How did your family celebrate holidays, birthdays, or Sundays?
- 12 Which traditions have you kept, and which do you miss?

SAYINGS, MUSIC & EVERYDAY LIFE

- 13 What music filled your home, church, or town?
- 14 What sayings or expressions did the grown-ups use?
- 15 What did an ordinary day look like? What chores did you have?
- 16 How did you hear the news? What did things cost?
- 17 What's something about your childhood that young people today might never believe?

LISTENER'S TIP Senses unlock memories. If an answer is short, try asking what a place smelled like, what could be heard from the front porch, or what was always on the kitchen table.

The People Who Shaped Me

No one becomes who they are alone.

- 1 Who influenced you the most when you were young?
- 2 What did they teach you, by their words or by their example?
- 3 Who made you feel safe? What did they do that made you feel that way?
- 4 Whose advice do you still hear in your head today?
- 5 What family saying have you carried with you? What does it mean to you?
- 6 Was there someone outside your family, a neighbor, pastor, coach, boss, or friend, who changed the direction of your life?
- 7 Who believed in you before you believed in yourself?
- 8 Who do you think you are most like? In what ways?
- 9 Is there someone you never got the chance to thank? What would you say to them now?

A Person I Want Our Family to Remember

Write their name, how they were connected, and one thing they said or did that the storyteller never forgot.

NAME	CONNECTION
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____
_____	_____

LISTENER'S TIP When a name comes up that you don't recognize, gently ask, "Who was that?" Many families lose track of the in-between people: the neighbor who took the kids in, the friend who was "practically an uncle." Their names deserve a place in the record.

Hard Roads & Strong Roots

What carried you through, and what you carried out of it.

A Note of Care Before You Ask

These questions are about *strength*, not about reliving pain. Let the storyteller decide how much to share. You do not need the details of what happened; you are listening for what helped. If a memory becomes heavy, it's perfectly fine to pause, sit quietly together, change the subject, or stop for the day. The story will wait. A simple "Thank you for trusting me with that" is always enough.

- 1 Was there a time when life asked a lot of you?
Share as much or as little as you like.
- 2 What helped you keep going?
- 3 Who stood beside you during that season?
- 4 Where did you find strength: faith, family, work, music, the land, your community?
- 5 Was there a moment you surprised yourself with how strong you were?
- 6 How did your family or community pull together when times were hard?
- 7 What did a difficult time teach you that an easy time never could have?
- 8 What are you most grateful for, looking back?
- 9 What would you tell someone facing something similar today?

Roots That Held

A person, a practice, a place, a verse, a song, or a belief that helped the storyteller hold steady:

For listeners: if a conversation brings up memories that seem to trouble the storyteller long after you've finished, it can help to check in with them later, or to encourage them to talk with someone they trust, such as a family member, faith leader, counselor, or veterans' service organization.

Things Worth Remembering

Every keepsake is a story waiting for someone to ask about it.



Ask the storyteller to choose one object, or bring one yourself, and let it lead the conversation. Some ideas:

a photograph

a recipe card

a letter or postcard

a piece of jewelry

a family Bible

a military medal or uniform

a tool

a quilt

a song or hymn

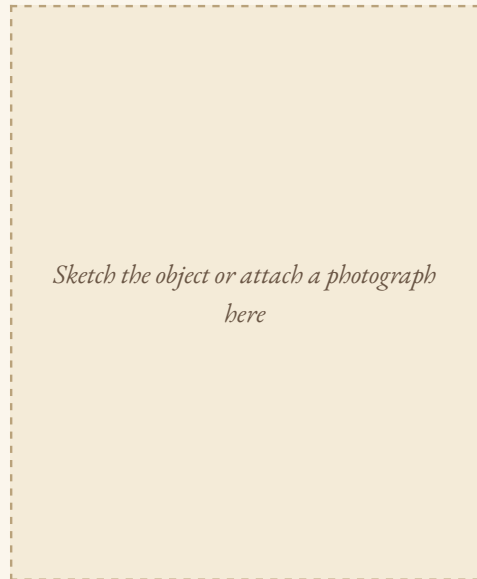
a dish or cast-iron skillet

a report card

a hat or pocketknife

a family tradition

- 1 What is it, and where did it come from?
- 2 Who owned it first? How did it come to you?
- 3 What memory comes to mind when you hold it, see it, or hear it?
- 4 Was it used every day, or saved for special occasions?
- 5 What would be lost if no one knew its story?
- 6 Who should care for it next, and what should they know?



*Sketch the object or attach a photograph
here*

The Story of This Keepsake

ITEM _____

FIRST OWNED BY _____

KEPT NOW BY _____

LISTENER'S TIP Recipes are stories too. If the object is a recipe, ask who taught it, what occasion it was made for, and what the "secret" is that never got written down.

What I Want You to Know

The wisdom, values, and hopes one generation hands to the next.

-
- 1 What are you most proud of in your life?
- 2 What do you wish you had understood when you were younger?
- 3 What values do you hope will continue in our family?
- 4 What advice would you give the next generation?
- 5 What does a good life mean to you now? Has that changed over time?
- 6 What is something you would do again in a heartbeat?
- 7 What makes you hopeful about the future?
- 8 Is there a story you've never told that you would like to share now?
- 9 What do you hope people remember about you?

In Their Own Words

Invite the storyteller to write, or say aloud while you write, a message for someone in the family who hasn't been born yet.

To the ones who come after me...

SIGNED _____ DATE _____

What I Heard Today

Write this soon after your conversation, while the voice is still in your ears.



Something I learned...

Something that surprised me...

Something we have in common...

A story I don't want our family to lose...

Something I want to ask about next time...

Our Family Story Record

So that someone, years from now, will know who spoke, who listened, and what was saved.



STORY SHARED BY _____ DATE _____

INTERVIEWED BY _____ PLACE _____

RELATIONSHIP _____ OTHERS PRESENT _____

THEMES WE TALKED ABOUT

- ☐ Where It All Began ☐ The People Who Shaped Me ☐ Hard Roads & Strong Roots
☐ Things Worth Remembering ☐ What I Want You to Know

WHAT WAS PRESERVED FROM THIS CONVERSATION

TYPE	DESCRIPTION	WHERE IT IS KEPT
<i>Audio or video recording</i>		
<i>Photographs</i>		
<i>Letters & documents</i>		
<i>Recipes</i>		
<i>Keepsakes & objects</i>		
<i>Songs, sayings, other</i>		

Sharing Permission

The storyteller is comfortable with this conversation being:

- ☐ kept private with the listener ☐ shared within the family
☐ shared with a church, school, library, or historical group

ANYTHING TO KEEP PRIVATE _____

STORYTELLER'S SIGNATURE (OPTIONAL) _____

Keep the Story Going

One conversation is a beginning. Here are ways to keep the thread unbroken.



Interview Another Relative

Every person remembers the same family differently. A cousin, an in-law, or a sibling will fill in pieces no one else has.

Label Old Photographs

Sit together with a box of pictures. On the back, in soft pencil, write names, places, and approximate years while someone still knows them.

Preserve the Recipes

Copy handwritten cards before they fade. Note who made the dish, when it was served, and the “pinch of this” that never made it onto the card.

Record Family Sayings

Start a running list of the expressions, blessings, and warnings your family repeats. Note who said them and what they meant.

Create a Small Family Archive

A labeled box or binder is enough to begin. Keep recordings in two places, and name each file with the storyteller’s name and the date.

Share a Story Forward

Choose a story that suits younger listeners and tell it at a holiday meal, a birthday, or bedtime. Stories stay alive by being retold.

Using This Guide with a Group

Churches, libraries, classrooms, veterans’ groups, senior centers, and family reunions can all make this a shared activity:

- ◆ **Pair people across generations** and give each pair one theme and about 30–45 minutes.
- ◆ **Open with the listening principles** on page 3, and remind everyone that any question can be skipped.
- ◆ **Invite a “keepsake table”** where people bring an object and share its story aloud.
- ◆ **Close with a sharing circle**, where listeners retell one story they heard, with the storyteller’s permission.

THE STORY CONTINUES

Pass It Forward



Stories are not only found in books. They live in families, communities, memories, and the people willing to preserve them.



Find more free guides and activities in the JPP Resource Center

[[Resource Center link](#)]

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